

Turning up more than box scores

There used to be 16 teams in major league baseball; now there are 18 that train in Florida alone. You can't see all 18 in a two-week tour of Florida. But, after circling from Tampa to Palm Beach to Miami to Ft. Myers, and some points between, we found a few things besides box scores.

Graig Nettles of the Yankees, asked if winning the American League home run championship had any effect: "Yes, sports writers spell my first name right, now."

Bill Campbell, who went from the Twins to the Red Sox for big money in the free-agent draft, sent his former manager, Gene Mauch, a postcard: "Thanks for making me a better and richer pitcher."

Al Hrabosky of the Cardinals, forced to shave his mustache in the team's new dress code: "I shaved it off in the bathroom. I didn't want anybody to see a grown man cry."

Pete Vuckovich of the new Toronto Blue Jays, also forced to shave because his team has the same dress code: "Don't they know I've had a mustache since I was 17." Pete is 24 now.

● **THE COLD WEATHER** which preceded the training season caused a lot of comment. A good 3-year-old named Royal Ski was in training at Gulfstream, and if he'd run many races, he'd have been popular with the hunch players.

One sports writer thought he was catching flu and was advised to move to Dunedin. "There's an expansion team there, the Blue Jays, and nobody's catching anything."

● **THE LAST WEEKEND** in Florida was the Jewish Passover. Some of the Irish sports writers were thinking about their Jewish friends, and we picked an all-

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time Jewish baseball team. Here it is:

First base, Hank Greenberg; second, Andy Cohen; short, Murray Franklin; third, Al Rosen; outfield, Morrie Aronovitch, Sid Gordon and Art Shamsky; catcher, Moe Berg; pitcher, Sandy Koufax.

Such a team would need a fine trainer, so we nominated Roland Schwartz, who did a great job running the U. S. boxing team in the Olympics.

The coach would be Al Schacht, the batboy George Jessel. (That's not as far-fetched as it seems; Jessel was a New York Giants batboy for John McGraw.)

There would be great sports writers covering the team, and our nominations were Morris Siegel, Washington Star, in the east; Si Burick, Dayton Daily News, midwest; Mickey Herskowitz, Houston, southwest; Mel Durslag, Los Angeles Examiner, far west; and Milt Richman, UPI, on a national basis. All are prize-winning journalists.

● **GOING SOUTH FOR** spring training is a geography lesson. Skyline Chili, which has 18 locations in Cincinnati, has opened No. 19 at Ft. Lauderdale, and No. 20 is starting soon in Tampa on the same street where the Reds play ball.

Thousands of Cincinnatians go to Florida when the Reds train, and this year some of them stopped at Plains, Ga., on the way down. They boarded a mini-bus

for a tour of the town, and at 1 p. m. they met at the railroad station, where Miss Lillian gave autographs. Karl Mouch, the Carthage jeweler, and Mrs. Mouch had their picture taken with Miss Lillian.

I didn't go to Plains but I noticed throughout southern Georgia a chain of cafeterias called Davis Bros., and they all have a sign that says, "We Feature Home-Made Peanut Pie."

At Boca Raton, I talked to Tom Nieporte, former Cincinnati city golf champion, former winner of the Bob Hope Classic, now the pro at Piping Rock on Long Island. He winters at Boca Raton and plays in executive matches arranged for him by New York corporations.

At Tampa, the owner of the Yankees, George Steinbrenner, played in a celebrity softball game and remarked, "That ball looks as big as a grapefruit." That gave somebody an idea. When Steinbrenner came to bat, the pitcher slipped in a real grapefruit, George hit it and splattered himself in the face.

At Lakeland, Mark Fidrych, the Tigers pitcher who talks to the baseball, attended a celebrity dinner. Comedian Pat Henry said, "Fidrych's been talking to his steak 20 minutes." And Lefty Gomez said, "I was the first pitcher who talked to baseballs. When a guy hit one down the line on me, I'd yell, 'Go foul, you son of a gun, go foul!'"

At Gainesville, George Steinbrenner donated the U. of Florida a set of lights for the baseball diamond, and the Yankees played an exhibition there. During the game someone stole Elston Howard's glove and Chris Chambliss' equipment bag. One Yankee said, George "Instead of lights, should have given 'em a set of burglar alarms."

And this shows you how mixed up things are today: it's the opening of the baseball season, and the basketball referees are calling "Strike!"